

SPAM-PROTECT

Your Inbox

A look at some anti-spam organisations that have come up with radical new ways to help fight unwanted mail that clogs up our inbox everyday

The Internet has shrunk our world, bringing people across continents together at a click of the mouse. But in most cases, our mailboxes contain more unfriendly, unsolicited e-mail than a congenial note from the friend across the ocean. Spam is growing to become one of the largest and most annoying problems faced on the Net today. It is also big business for the bulk mailers—they can send out millions of messages every day and make thousands of dollars in the process.

Unwanted e-mail is not only irritating, but also harmful—hoaxes offering weight loss pills and holiday discounts clog mailboxes, causing important messages to bounce back. Companies lose unimaginably large amounts of money. Studies conducted on the Internet show that spam costs businesses close to \$10 billion (Rs 5,00,000 crore) every year, just for the bandwidth! Add to this the cost of anti-spam measures in terms of software and manpower to manage the software. Internet Service Providers (ISPs) suffer the most: the spam affects them in the form of

outgoing messages as well as incoming mail. It also drastically slows down networks and many a small ISP has been known to shut down because of huge amounts of spam.

Over the years, hundreds of ways of avoiding spam have been suggested and adopted. However, these were all dependent on the end-user. Using unintelligent filters in your mail client, understanding the methods of bulk mailers and adopting practices to discourage them, and using third-party spam-blocking software

from the list and sometimes, just reading the e-mail is enough to let spammers know that yours is an active e-mail address so that they can bombard you with even more messages. It is just not possible to cultivate disciplined practices to discourage spam across millions of users. Thus, some amount of spam always manages to reach your mailbox.

Spammers use software known as e-mail harvesters, which crawl Web sites just like search engines, and gather any e-mail addresses found inside them. To protect

“ It only takes one sucker in 10,000 to make a spam operation economical ”

— Jason Catlett, President of Junkbusters, an anti-spam organisation

are some of the most popular means suggested. However, spammers have always managed to stay a step ahead and circumvent all such means. Simple things such as clicking on any of the links in a mail, replying to it, trying to unsubscribe

their sites, many administrators have installed anti-harvesting scripts. However, not all servers implement good security measures and spammers are always able to acquire huge lists of e-mail addresses from corporate sites, forums, newsgroups,